UC SANTA CRUZ

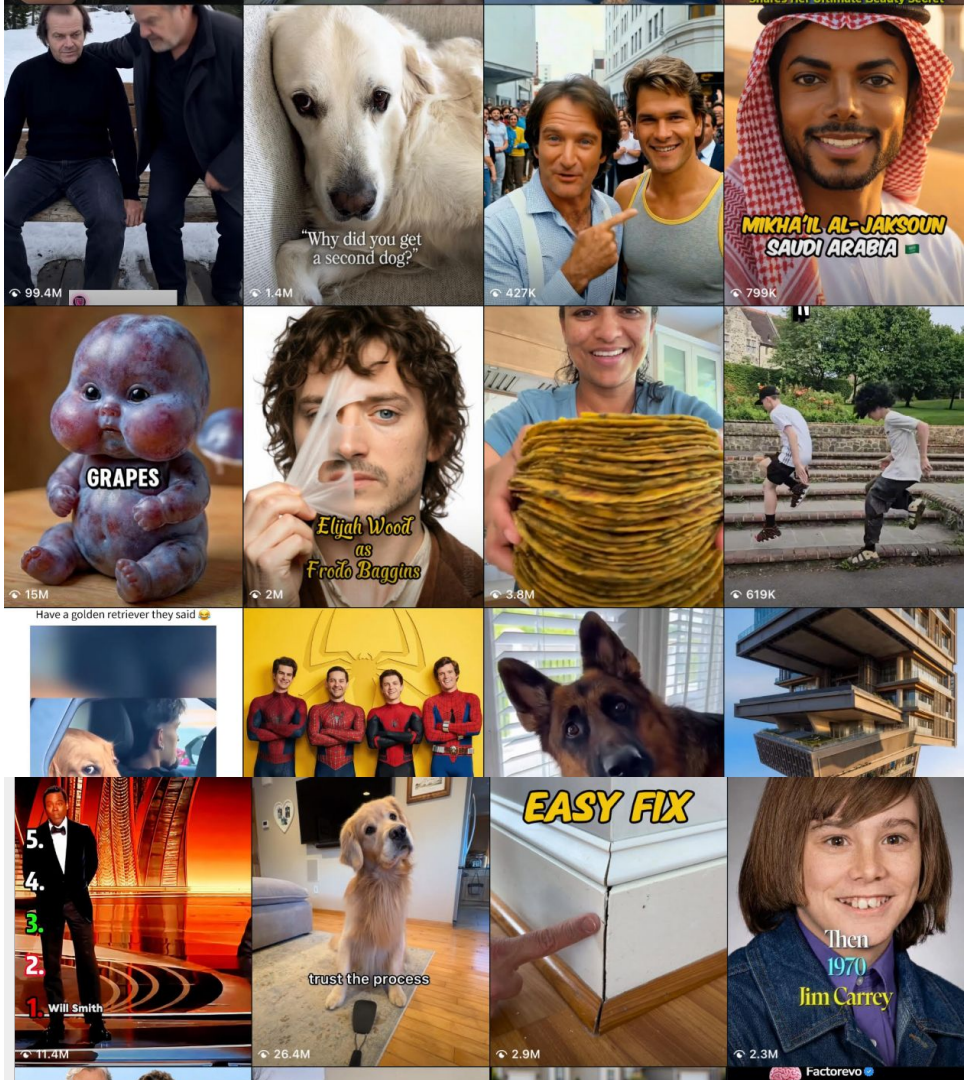
The Post-Attention Economy: Re-Designing Social Platforms for End User Value

By Manya Saxena

Our attention is our most valuable asset.

The current model exploits this

Any type of social consumer software is currently modeled after a slot machine. The goal is now maximal extraction of human attention.

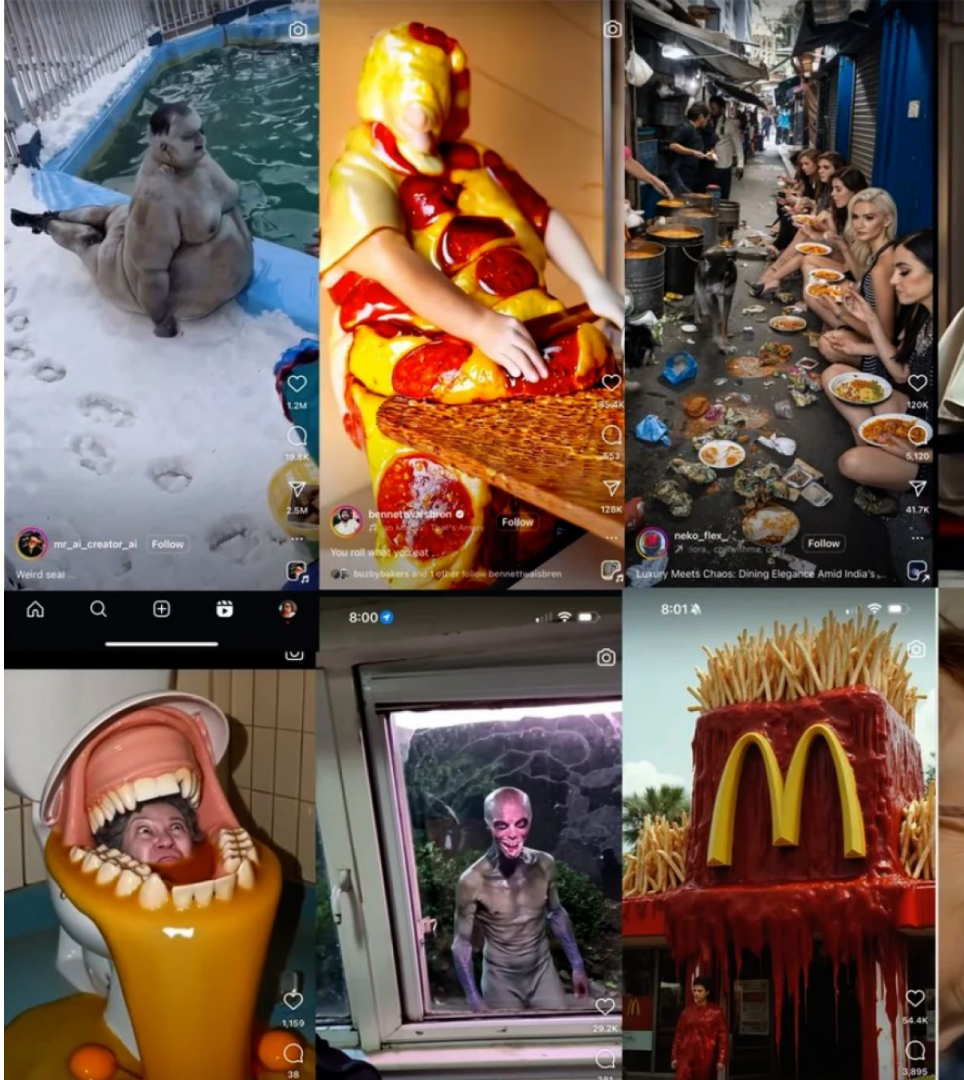


Design Mechanisms Driving the Attention Economy

- Intrusive Push Notifications
- Variable Reward "Slot-Machines"
- FOMO-Driven Social Proof
- Emotional Engagement Triggers
- Divisive Algorithmic Amplification
- Opaque Data Mining
- Hostile "Roach Motel" Interfaces
- Passive Consumption Loops
- Infinite Scroll

And now.. The AI Escalation

Hyper Personalization to the Extreme



We have reached a global tipping point

Lawmakers are finally treating the attention economy as a public health hazard.

New York to require social media platforms to display mental health warnings

By **Jasper Ward**

December 26, 2025 1:08 PM PST · Updated December 26, 2025

Aa

Australia's Social Media Ban for Children Takes Effect

The measure, which affects anyone under 16, is one of the most sweeping efforts in the world to safeguard young people from the potential harms of the platforms.

Reclaiming Human Agency

As designers, we must acknowledge that if a platform designed to connect people becomes an addictive echo chamber, the design has failed.

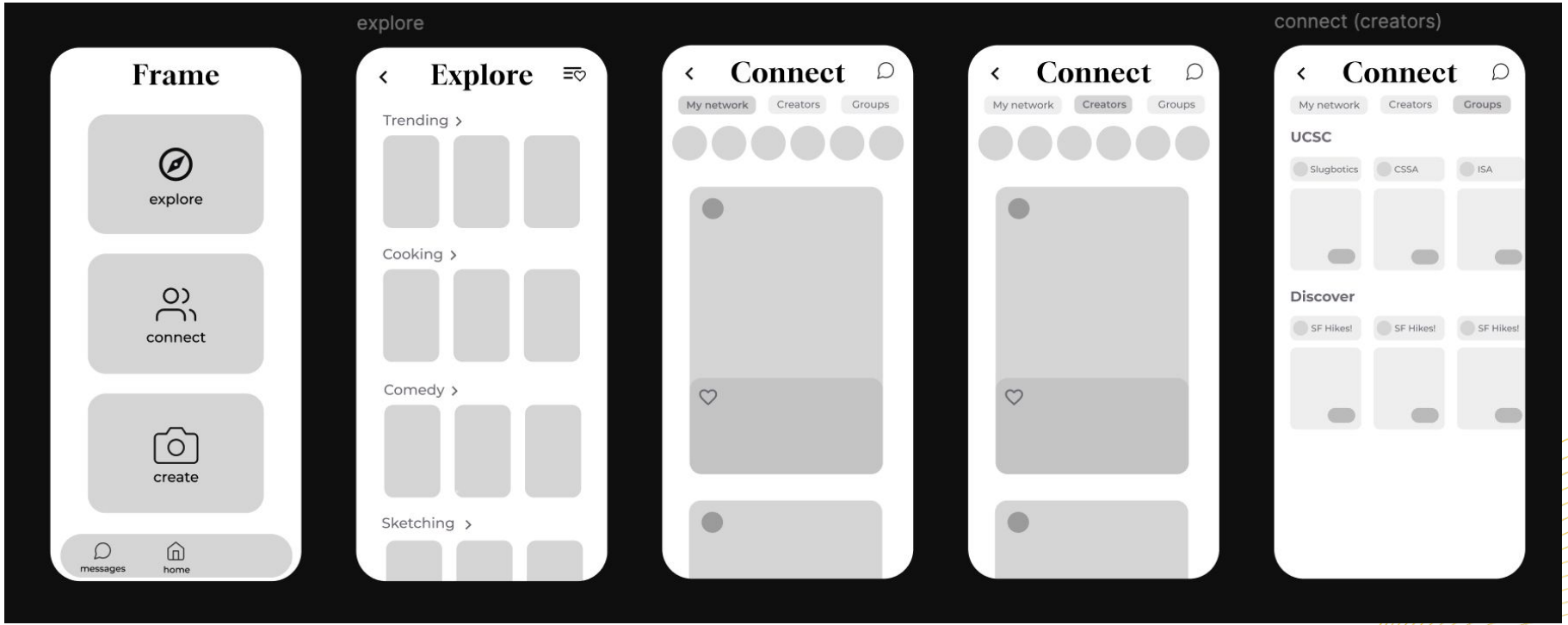
We must adopt **Value-Sensitive Design (VSD)**: a framework that embeds ethical human values directly into the software architecture, rather than treating them as an afterthought.

The Commercial Strategy

We cannot solve the attention crisis using an ad-based business model.

Value Based SaaS: Implementing a subscription or consumable model where the price scales with the actual, measurable value delivered to the user.

Shifting from Attention Extraction to Value Generation

Optimizing for **raw screen time** and session length.	→	Optimizing for **"Time Well Spent"** and psychological well-being.
Frictionless interfaces (infinite scroll, autoplay).	→	Finite design with **natural stopping cues.**
Proprietary, **opaque algorithms** controlling the user's feed	→	Algorithmic choice driven by **user control.**
Vanity metrics driving performance (likes, follower counts).	→	Metrics tailored to **end user intent** and **value generation**.

A Value-Driven Social Platform: Early Design Concepts